

Pre-Analysis Plan for “Divorce risk and household specialization”

1. Introduction

This document pre-specifies the analysis we will conduct with data from our baseline survey and administrative data. We will submit separate pre-analysis plans for the follow up surveys before we start the data collection for these waves.

The research goal of this study is to test whether exposure to a divorce experience can increase women’s perception of divorce risk and divorce-related financial risks. In addition, we measure whether exposure to a divorce experience may change women’s willingness to take preventive measures to mitigate these risks. To test this hypothesis, we design a field experiment in which women are exposed to real testimonials sharing their “divorce related experience” in a video. We compare this treatment to a control group that receives videos with unrelated information.

The randomized control trial will be implemented among women aged 25 to 50 who work in public schools in Switzerland.

2. Description of the intervention

To test how learning through a divorce experience can impact women’s perceptions and behaviors, we design a testimonial intervention. We do this through a video that features two real women sharing their own personal experiences regarding the financial risk from a reduced workload in case of divorce and potential strategies to mitigate this risk. We selected these two examples to provide two relevant perspectives: one, a woman who specialized in household care and experienced a divorce and the related financial consequences, and the other, a woman who, together with her partner, decided to take preventive measures to mitigate the financial risks associated with (relative) household specialization. Overall, the testimonial intervention has the goal to normalize that divorce can happen to anyone, shed light on the financial consequences after a divorce process in terms of pension gaps, and to provide examples and inspiration for taking proactive steps to mitigate financial risks within a relationship. The testimonials emphasize the importance of communication within the couple about the financial risk of specialization, the importance of the workload choice, and/or to financially compensate a reduced workload within the partnership.

The control group receives a video of similar duration but on an unrelated topic. We use videos created by the national public television as part of their regular programming (<https://www.srf.ch/>). We randomize the control group into the following videos:

- a video portraying people talking about seeing a psychologist and the taboo of seeking help for mental health.
- a video explaining how digital media, particularly mobile devices, can have a detrimental impact on family bonds and impede the cognitive development of children, with a focus on explaining findings from research.

3. Recruitment of participants and timeline

The field experiment will be implemented by inviting female staff working in schools via email and physical letters in two regions in Switzerland.

In Region A, we will generate individualized survey links for school staff, and the regional authorities will oversee the distribution of survey invitations through letters. In Region B, the regional authorities will establish contact with school principals by email, providing them with the survey link to our study. Subsequently, the school principals will forward this invitation to the staff within their respective schools, also through email.

We time the receipt of the letter or email during the second half of November 2023, before teachers start conversations with school principals about their desired workload for the upcoming academic year. This process typically starts at the beginning of December.

4. Randomization

We randomize participants entering the survey into treatment and control at the individual level. Within the control video, we randomize the two control videos with equal probability.

We stratify the randomization based on the following characteristics of participants: whether they are teachers, whether they have children/are pregnant, whether they have a partner, whether they work full-time, whether they previously divorced, and by region. Our main sample of interest are women with children who do not work full-time (workload < 90%) and who currently have a partner.

5. Primary outcomes

The intervention is hypothesized to:

- 1) Move beliefs about the likelihood of divorce and about the financial risks associated with divorce.
- 2) Increase the willingness to take steps to mitigate the financial risks associated with divorce.

For 1) we measure participants' perceptions about divorce risk and financial risks associated with divorce. For measuring the divorce risk, we use a list experiment: within each treatment group, we randomize two questions. In one, participants are asked to estimate the separation probability of four couples of close friends, in the other, participants are asked to estimate the separation probability of four couples of close friends and themselves. We will combine questions that measure the perception of financial risk of divorce into an index. This includes the perceived divorce risk, the perceived probability of future income pooling, and beliefs about the financial risks of household specialization.

For 2) we measure the following outcomes:

- Workload: We measure workload intentions for the next schoolyear and for future years. We will further analyze workload choices for next school year using administrative data provided by employers.
- Taking steps (non-workload related) to mitigate financial risk: We examine the intentions of taking steps to mitigate the financial risk for the person who specializes more in home production. We will also analyze which type of steps participants intend to take, such as their desire to increase savings, get more information, or talk with their partner.¹

As part of taking steps to mitigate the financial risk, we include an incentivized outcome to capture willingness to negotiate for compensation for household specialization:

Participants are offered access to an online tool that allows couples to have a reference point to start thinking about a financial compensation for caretaking responsibilities. In essence, the tool provides this information by calculating the long-term financial costs of reduced workloads. Participants choose between receiving the full 500 CHF voucher for study participation or receiving a voucher of 490 CHF plus access to the tool if they win the raffle. We will also examine the likelihood of sharing the tool with their partner.

- In addition to the outcomes discussed, we will also examine the emotional reaction of women after exposure to the intervention.

Note that we do not expect all outcomes to necessarily move simultaneously, as the adjustment in each dimension will depend on the personal situation and constraints of the family.

¹ We do not have a clear hypothesis for the direction of adjustment in terms of communication with the partner. On one hand, we would expect increased communication if women wish to seek compensation. On the other hand, the financial risks related to household specialization and divorce could be a sensitive topic among couples. We will use the comparison with the two control groups to examine adjustments in this outcome.

6. Empirical Strategy

Main analysis

In order to measure the impact of our intervention, we estimate the following model:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Treat_i + \beta_2 X_i + \varepsilon_i$$

where Y_i is the outcome of interest for teacher i . $Treat_i$ is an indicator for treatment status of teacher i , X_i is the vector of individual level baseline (pre-determined) covariates, and ε_i is an error term. We use heteroskedasticity robust standard errors and include strata fixed effects.

X_i are baseline teacher characteristics that are predictive of the outcome in the control group or are unbalanced at baseline between treatment and control potentially affecting precision or introducing bias. Following Belloni, Chernozhukov, and Hansen (ReStud 2013), we will mainly employ LASSO (post-double-selection) to determine the controls we include in the regression.

As we expect workload decisions to be fairly persistent, we will consider the inclusion of desired workload for the next academic year measured at baseline, or workload in the previous year (from the admin data), as a control to increase precision. For workload outcomes (desired and actual workload), we will also test the impact by defining the outcome as the change in the desired workload after versus before the intervention.²

7. Heterogeneity analysis

We describe below the dimensions we consider for heterogeneity analysis:

- By potential (organizational) constraints in the household (ease of organizing family life, age of their youngest child,...)
- By previous workload
- By previous divorce experience and knowledge about divorce, and interest in divorce topics.
- By relative household specialization and future career expectations
- By level of communication with partner
- By whether the family is budget constrained
- By gender norm views
- By marital status and marital stability

² In case of suspecting potential spillover effects, we will analyze “snowball patterns” in the data to identify schools and individuals more likely to be exposed to spillover effects. This will be based on the within-school time patterns in taking the survey, as well as using variation in the share of teachers that were treated. We will in addition also examine the likelihood of talking with colleagues about the intervention.